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Jonah

Jonah 1:1–3:10

In 2 Kings 14:25 Jonah was described as a servant of the Lord.

In the book of Jonah, God wanted Jonah to share a message of judgement. This message was against the city of Nineveh. But Jonah didn't obey God or show respect for God. He didn't go right away to share God's message with the Assyrians in Nineveh. Instead, he ran away.

This was different from what the plants, animals and weather in this story did. God sent a strong wind and a huge fish. God caused a leafy plant to grow. He also sent a worm and an east wind. The plant, the animals and the wind all obeyed their Creator.

The way that Jonah treated God was also different from how the sailors treated God. The sailors weren't Hebrew like Jonah was. They didn't worship only God. But they did show respect for God. They showed it by crying out to God for help and by offering sacrifices to him.

Jonah's prayer was like many poems in the book of Psalms that give thanks to God. Jonah thanked God for saving him from drowning in the Mediterranean Sea. Yet Jonah didn't admit that he had done anything wrong. He didn't say that he was sorry for not obeying God. He didn't ask God to forgive him.

This was different from what the king, the nobles and the people of Nineveh did. When Jonah announced God's message of judgement, they admitted that they had done evil things. Right away they went without eating. Fasting and wearing rough clothes were common practices in that time. They were ways that people showed that they turned away from their sin and repented. The Ninevites didn't allow their animals to have food for a time either. The king sat in the dust. This showed that he made himself humble before God. The people stopped harming others. They repented and prayed to God with all their heart. All of these actions showed how serious the Ninevites were about changing their ways.

God's anger at their sin stopped. He showed them pity and mercy.

Jonah 4:1–11

Jonah's anger started when God's anger stopped. He thought that he was right to be angry. He thought that God was wrong to stop being angry. Jonah didn't want God to show his tender love to the Assyrians.

People from the family line of Jacob considered the Assyrians to be outsiders. The Assyrians had treated God's people badly for many years. Jonah wanted God to bring judgement against them and destroy them.

Jonah cared about the plant that God had caused to grow. The plant gave him shade and made him feel comfortable. Jonah's anger grew when the plant died. He cared more about the plant than he did about human beings from Assyria.

God cared about the plant and took care of it. He also cared about Jonah and about the people and the animals of Nineveh. God had made himself known to Moses as the God who is tender and kind. God is gracious and slow to get angry. God is faithful and full of love (Exodus 34:6).

Jonah understood that God was tender, kind and full of love for the Israelites (Israel). But Jonah didn't want God to be that way for the people of Nineveh. God showed Jonah that he was full of love for everything and everyone that he created. This included those whom God's people considered to be their enemies.